



penalty corners, collaborating with the analysts to understand the variations employed by different teams. This preparation is invaluable during matches," he said. "We have Amit Rohidas, one of the best first runners, along with Manpreet [Singh], Harmanpreet, and Jarmanpreet guarding the goalpost. Our penalty corner defence deserves a lot of credit too.

"When you have such a strong defensive unit, it instills confidence and trust in the team. At the Olympics, out of 57 penalty corners, we conceded only five goals, including straight flicks and rebounds. That's an incredible achievement," the goalkeeper added. Off the field, Pathak has embraced the joy of fatherhood.

"I feel really good because when I see him, especially during training breaks when I call and see his smile, it gives me a special feeling and motivation," he said about Jayden, his six-month old son.

"There are so many things happening around you. You have to

take care of your family and the baby. It's a lot of fun. I don't feel any extra pressure, and I'm thoroughly enjoying this phase of my life," he shared. Despite his best efforts over the years, including winning the Baljit Singh Award For Goalkeeper Of The Year twice (2019, 2022), an Olympic medal still eludes him. Pathak travelled with the team as a reserve goalkeeper for both Tokyo 2020 and Paris 2024, but Olympic rules meant that only members of the main squad [18 in Tokyo and 16 in Paris] received medals.

"There is some sorrow. I've been part of the team for over six years, but there's also pride in being part of

Prudent call: Much credit goes to former coach Graham Reid's strategy of rotating Krishan Pathak and P.R. Sreejesh, with each playing two quarters per game, for Pathak's seamless transition. BISWARANJAN ROUT

this squad," he said.

"When I returned home this time, my wife told me, 'The team won bronze the two times you travelled with them; maybe next time when you play, the colour will be gold.' Her words give me added motivation."

"Jo maine nahi paaya...usey paana hai (What I haven't achieved yet... I must achieve)."

« On the field, Krishan Pathak's biggest challenge will be to replicate P.R. Sreejesh's dominance in goal »